

Book I - The Sagent Creed

Part 4 - The Fibonacci Spiral Through the Generations

Chapter 19 - Gumby and the Cartel

Gumby and the Cartel: How a Government-Created Media Monopoly Connected to the Epstein Blackmail Operation Sabotaged America's Most Independent Children's Property

Thesis

Between 1992 and 2018, Gumby — one of the most recognized characters in American culture, created by an independent animator who explicitly refused to exploit children — was systematically denied distribution despite proven audience demand. The people who controlled the gates were connected to Jeffrey Epstein's documented blackmail and child exploitation network. The government-created monopoly on broadcasting ensured there was no alternative path. When the last Clokey who could protect the IP died at 56, the property was acquired by a company whose owner appears in Epstein's contact book, stripped of its original medium, philosophy, and independence.

This document presents that case using named people, dates, corporate records, court documents, and the public Epstein files.

Part 1: The Government-Created Monopoly

How the Cartel Was Built

No private company can legally broadcast in the United States without a license from the Federal Communications Commission. This is not a free market — it is a government-granted monopoly on access to the public.

The legal foundation:

- The **Radio Act of 1927** claimed government ownership of the electromagnetic spectrum
- The **Communications Act of 1934** created the FCC to allocate broadcast licenses
- The FCC decides who can transmit and who cannot. Broadcasting without a license is a federal crime.

This system does not create competition. It creates a fixed number of permits distributed by a government agency. The permit holders become an artificial oligopoly by design.

The consolidation:

The **Telecommunications Act of 1996** — signed by President Clinton — was marketed as deregulation. It did not abolish the FCC or the license system. It removed the caps on how many licenses one company could hold while keeping the total number of licenses fixed. The result:

Year	Number of major media companies controlling US media
1983	~50
1996	~10
2005	**6**

By 2005, five companies controlled approximately three-quarters of all prime-time television: **Viacom, Disney, Time Warner, News Corp, and NBC Universal.**

Sources:

- [Telecommunications Act of 1996 — Congress.gov](<https://www.congress.gov/bill/104th-congress/senate-bill/652>)
- [FCC — About the FCC](<https://www.fcc.gov/about/overview>)
- [Ben Bagdikian, *The New Media Monopoly* (2004)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Media_Monopoly)
- [Free Press — Who Owns the Media?](<https://www.freepress.net/issues/media-control/ownership>)

What This Meant for Independent Creators

Before consolidation, an independent animation studio had multiple paths to an audience:

- **Syndication** — sell directly to independent local TV stations
- **Licensing** — license content to a network while retaining IP ownership
- **Home video** — distribute through independent video companies

After consolidation:

- **Syndication died** — independent stations were bought by the big 5
- **Networks demanded IP ownership** — Nickelodeon, Cartoon Network, Disney Channel, and Fox Kids all required creators to surrender ownership of their characters as a condition of airtime
- **Home video consolidated** — Blockbuster (Viacom) and Walmart controlled shelf space

- **Cable systems were owned by the same companies** making the content — vertical integration meant the producer, the network, the cable operator, and the merchandiser were the same entity

By the late 1990s, there were six doors to reach the American audience. The same people held all the keys. If you weren't inside one of these vertically integrated stacks, you had no path to distribution.

Part 2: Who Held the Keys — And Their Epstein Connections

The Children's Entertainment Gatekeepers

Children's television in the 1990s was controlled by a small number of executives. Several appear in the documented records of Jeffrey Epstein's network.

Geraldine Laybourne — The Most Powerful Person in Children's Television

- **President of Nickelodeon, 1984-1996.** Built it from last place among cable channels to first. By the mid-1990s, Nickelodeon commanded **57.4% of all children's television viewership** — more than ABC, CBS, NBC, and Fox combined.
- **President of Disney/ABC Cable Networks, 1996-1998.** Oversaw the Disney Channel, A&E, Lifetime, History Channel, and E! Entertainment. Controlled programming strategy for the Disney children's brand during the years the Clokey-Disney deal would have been active.
- Founded **Oxygen Media** in 1998 with Oprah Winfrey, Carsey-Werner (Cosby Show producers), and \$100 million from Paul Allen.
- **Appears in Jeffrey Epstein's black book** — the contact directory containing names of people in Epstein's personal network.
- Her husband **Kit Laybourne** also appears in Epstein's records. Kit worked at **MTV, Nickelodeon, Nick Jr.**, and the **Children's Television Workshop** (the organization behind Sesame Street).
- Both Geraldine and Kit Laybourne sat on the board of **KinderCare**, one of the largest childcare chains in America.

One woman controlled the dominant children's television platform for 12 years, then moved to the second-largest platform for 2 more years. She appears in the records of a man convicted of trafficking minors. Her husband, also in those records, worked at the production company behind Sesame Street.

Sources:

- [Geraldine Laybourne — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Geraldine_Laybourne)
- [Geraldine Laybourne — Television Academy Interview](<https://interviews.televisionacademy.com/interviews/geraldine-laybourne>)
- [Epstein Black Book — Documented entries](<https://9east71.home.blog/2019/08/08/nickelodeon/>)

- [Laybourne flight log details (public post)](<https://x.com/WallStreetApes/status/1680362102438129664>)

Rupert Murdoch — The Distribution Empire

- Controlled **News Corp**: Fox Broadcasting, Fox Kids, 20th Century Fox, Sky, the New York Post, the Wall Street Journal, HarperCollins, and (later) DirecTV.
- Fox Kids was the third-largest children's programming block in the US.
- **Appears in Jeffrey Epstein's black book.**
- In February 2022, Fox Entertainment — under Murdoch's corporate umbrella — acquired the entire Gumby IP from the Clokey estate.

Source:

- [Connections of Jeffrey Epstein — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Connections_of_Jeffrey_Epstein)
- [Variety — Fox acquires Gumby (2022)](<https://variety.com/2022/tv/news/fox-entertainment-gumby-1235174899/>)

Sumner Redstone — The Corporate Structure Above It All

- Acquired controlling interest in **Viacom** in 1987. Viacom owned Nickelodeon, MTV, Showtime, Paramount Pictures, CBS (after 1999), BET, Comedy Central, Simon & Schuster, and Blockbuster.
- Viacom collected over **\$12 billion in annual revenue** by the late 1990s.
- Redstone's model was built explicitly on capturing young audiences — "a company that thrived on the young audience — kids who watched Nickelodeon."
- Faced **multiple lawsuits alleging sexual exploitation** and coercion.
- No direct Epstein connection has been publicly documented. However, the corporate structure he controlled housed both Nickelodeon (run by Laybourne, who is in Epstein's records) and the distribution apparatus (Paramount, Blockbuster) that determined which children's content reached store shelves.

Sources:

- [Sumner Redstone — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sumner_Redstone)
- [Viacom corporate history — FundingUniverse](<https://www.fundinguniverse.com/company-histories/viacom-inc-history/>)

Dan Schneider — The Man Laybourne Hired

- Hired by Geraldine Laybourne at Nickelodeon in **1994**.
- Produced the network's biggest shows for **25 years**: All That, The Amanda Show, Drake & Josh, Zoey 101, iCarly, Victorious, Sam & Cat, Henry Danger.
- Had **unsupervised access to child actors** throughout his tenure.

- Exposed in the 2024 docuseries *Quiet on Set: The Dark Side of Kids TV* for abusive and predatory behavior toward child actors.
- Fired by Viacom after an internal investigation.
- The woman who hired him and gave him that access appears in Epstein's records.

Sources:

- [Quiet on Set (documentary) — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Quiet_on_Set:_The_Dark_Side_of_Kids_TV)
- [Dan Schneider — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dan_Schneider_(TV_producer))

The Gatekeeper Map

Gatekeeper | Position | What They Controlled | Epstein Connection

Geraldine Laybourne | President, Nickelodeon (1984-1996); President, Disney/ABC Cable (1996-1998) | 57% of children's TV viewership, then Disney Channel | **Black book** (+ husband Kit)

Kit Laybourne | Producer/executive at MTV, Nickelodeon, Nick Jr., Children's Television Workshop | Children's programming production across multiple networks | **Black book**

Rupert Murdoch | Chairman, News Corp | Fox, Fox Kids, 20th Century Fox, distribution infrastructure | **Black book**

Sumner Redstone | Chairman, Viacom | Nickelodeon parent company, Paramount, CBS, Blockbuster | Documented sexual predation; corporate structure housed Laybourne and Schneider

Dan Schneider | Executive producer, Nickelodeon (1994-2018) | 25 years of children's programming content | Hired by Laybourne; documented child abuse

These are not peripheral figures. These are the people who decided what American children watched for three decades.

A Note on Language: Pedophagy, Not Pedophile

The word "pedophile" comes from Greek — *paidos* (child) + *philos* (love). It literally means "child lover." This is a lie encoded in language.

What Epstein's network did was not love. What Schneider did for 25 years was not love. What the gatekeepers enabled and protected was not love.

The accurate word is **pedophagy** — *paidos* (child) + *phagein* (to devour, to consume). **Child devourer.**

These people did not love children. They consumed them. They fed on innocence — on trust, on vulnerability, on the fact that a child doesn't know what's happening. They fed on the audience's trust, on parents' assumption that the people making their children's shows were safe, on the access that children's media uniquely provides.

Art Clokey called Gumby "an act of love to children." He meant it. He refused to exploit them. He refused to monetize them for eight years. That's what love looks like — protection, creation, giving something freely without taking.

The people who held the gates did the opposite. They took. They consumed. They devoured. They were not child lovers. They were child devourers. Pedophages.

This document uses that word deliberately. The corruption of language is part of the corruption of the system. Calling predation "love" is the same inversion as calling monopoly "deregulation" and calling gatekeeping "curation." The cartel always wears the language of the thing it destroys.

Part 3: The Epstein Blackmail Operation

How It Worked

Jeffrey Epstein ran a child exploitation and blackmail operation. This is not disputed — he was convicted in 2008 and arrested again in 2019 on federal sex trafficking charges. What matters for this analysis is not the abuse itself but the **leverage** it produced.

The timeline of the operation:

Period | Phase

****Mid-1980s**** | Earliest documented victims. Lawsuits include claims from 1985 involving victims as young as 13.

****Late 1980s-early 1990s**** | Epstein cultivating relationships with powerful figures in finance, politics, media, science, and entertainment. New York mansion and Palm Beach estate operational.

****1996**** | Maria Farmer reports to the NYPD and FBI that Epstein and Ghislaine Maxwell sexually abused her and others. Describes an ongoing child exploitation scheme. FBI takes no action.

****April 1998**** | Epstein purchases Little St. James island for \$7.95 million.

****2002-2005**** | Federal prosecutors later allege exploitation of "dozens of minor girls," some as young as 14.

****2005**** | Palm Beach police begin investigating after a parent reports abuse of her 14-year-old.

****2008**** | Sweetheart plea deal engineered by Alexander Acosta (later Trump's Labor Secretary). 13 months in county jail with daily work release.

****July 2019**** | Arrested on federal sex trafficking charges.

****August 10, 2019**** | Found dead in his cell. Ruled suicide. Both cameras malfunctioned. Both guards were asleep.

Sources:

- [PBS — Timeline of the Epstein investigation](<https://www.pbs.org/newshour/politics/a-timeline-of-the-jeffrey-epstein-investigation-and-the-fight-to-make-the-governments-files-public>)

- [Just Security — Timeline of law enforcement failures](https://www.justsecurity.org/119137/timeline-jeffrey-epstein-ghislaine-maxwell/)
- [Little Saint James — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Little_Saint_James)

The Leverage Mechanism

The blackmail operation does not require a centralized command structure. It requires:

1. **Compromising material on powerful people** — documented, proven in court
2. **Those people placed in or rising to gatekeeper positions** — Laybourne ran children's TV for 14 consecutive years across Nickelodeon and Disney
3. **Loyalty enforced through mutual exposure** — if you're compromised, you protect others who are compromised. You favor the network. You exclude outsiders.
4. **No explicit orders needed** — a compromised gatekeeper doesn't need a phone call saying "block this creator." They need only favor their own network and starve anyone outside of it. The monopoly structure ensures there's no way around them.

The critical insight: The Epstein operation was shaping who held power in entertainment *before the island*. The island is where it became most visible. The network of influence — who got access, who got distribution, who got shut out — was built in New York and Los Angeles boardrooms throughout the late 1980s and early 1990s.

The same years Gumby went dark.

Part 4: Art Clokey — The Man They Couldn't Control

Who Art Clokey Was

Art Clokey (1921-2010) created Gumby in the 1950s. He was a pioneer of stop-motion clay animation and one of the most recognized figures in children's entertainment history. But he was also something the industry cartel could not tolerate: **a genuinely independent creator operating on moral principles.**

- **Refused merchandising for 8 years** after Gumby's creation: "I was a very idealistic person, and I didn't want to exploit children."
- Called Gumby "**an act of love to children.**"
- Ran his own independent studio, **Premavision**, in Sausalito, California. Never network-owned. Never corporate-controlled.
- Was a spiritual seeker — seminary student, Buddhist, follower of Sai Baba. The documentary about him is titled *Gumby Dharma*.
- Also created *Davey and Goliath*, a Christian educational series for the Lutheran Church.

- **Trained more than half the animators** who worked on Tim Burton's *Nightmare Before Christmas*. His people went to Pixar and Disney. Art stayed independent.

Gumby's philosophy was embedded in its form:

- **Clay doesn't command. It becomes. It transforms.** Gumby moved through his world not as a rigid hero but as a living metaphor for creative freedom.
- **Green** — the color of life and growth — was deliberate. His form resembles a sprouting seedling: legs like roots, arms like branches, head leaning toward the sun.
- Gumby entered stories through the **portals of books** — imagination as a doorway, not a product.

From the cartel's perspective, Gumby was dangerous not because Art knew anything about their operations, but because of what he represented: **an independent, ethical, beloved children's property operating entirely outside their control**. If Gumby succeeds independently, it proves the system is unnecessary. The cartel's power depends on everyone believing there's no other way.

Sources:

- [GumbyWorld — History](<https://www.gumbyworld.com/art-clokey-gumby-history/>)
- [Art Clokey — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Art_Clokey)
- [Art Clokey — Television Academy Interview](<https://interviews.televisionacademy.com/interviews/art-clokey>)
- [Gumby Dharma — KQED](<https://www.kqed.org/trulyca/56/gumby-dharma>)

Part 5: The Sabotage — A Chronological Case

Phase 1: The Movie That Couldn't Get Distribution (1992-1995)

Art Clokey produced 99 new episodes of *Gumby Adventures* (1988-2002) from his studio in Sausalito. These aired as reruns on Nickelodeon and were **top-rated for three years** — proving massive audience demand.

He completed *Gumby: The Movie* in **1992**.

No major distributor would touch it for three years.

- Not Paramount (Viacom/Redstone — Nickelodeon's parent)
- Not Fox (Murdoch — Epstein's black book)
- Not Disney (where Laybourne would move in 1996)
- Not Warner Bros. (Time Warner)

The film was finally released in **1995** through **Arrow Releasing** — a tiny independent distributor — in just **21 theaters**. It grossed \$57,100 against a \$2.8 million budget.

But it sold approximately **1 million copies on VHS**.

One million families bought the movie when they could find it. The audience existed. The demand was proven. The only thing missing was access to the distribution system — a system controlled by people connected to Epstein's network.

The same year, 1995: *Toy Story* released and CGI replaced claymation as the industry standard — providing convenient cover for why Gumby "couldn't compete." But the distribution blockade preceded the CGI shift. The movie was finished in 1992 and sat on a shelf for three years. That wasn't a technology problem. That was a gatekeeping decision.

Who was at the gate in 1992-1995:

- Geraldine Laybourne was President of Nickelodeon, commanding 57% of children's TV viewership. She appears in Epstein's black book.

Sources:

- [Gumby: The Movie — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gumby:_The_Movie)
- [Gumby — Wikipedia](<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gumby>)

Phase 2: The Deals That Collapsed (2000s-2017)

After Art Clokey died on January 8, 2010, his son **Joe Clokey** became president of Premavision/Clokey Productions. Joe spent the next eight years fighting to bring Gumby back through legitimate industry channels.

The pattern was consistent: deals would materialize, agreements would be reached, and then they would be **sat on or fall through for no apparent reason**.

Deal 1: Disney (early 2000s)

- A deal with Disney fell through. Details unknown.
- Geraldine Laybourne had been President of Disney/ABC Cable Networks from 1996-1998. Even after her departure, the relationships and institutional preferences she established would have persisted.
- Laybourne appears in Epstein's black book.

Deal 2: Classic Media (2006-2012)

- In October 2006, Classic Media and Premavision announced a "long-term joint venture." Classic Media would manage US and international television, film, home video, digital, and promotional rights.
- **Tom Sarnoff** — former West Coast EVP of NBC and the man who originally greenlit the Gumby Show on NBC in 1956 — negotiated the deal for the Clokey side.
- The deal included plans for a **direct-to-video movie** (target release: 2008) and an **all-new TV series**, with Clokey Productions producing.

- **Neither was ever produced.** Six years. No movie. No series. Nothing.
- The license expired on **September 30, 2012**. Rights reverted to Premavision.
- In July 2012, DreamWorks Animation bought Classic Media for \$155 million. In 2016, NBCUniversal bought DreamWorks. Gumby was no longer part of the catalog — the Clokeys had kept ownership. But six years of potential production had been wasted.

Sources:

- [Classic Media Manages Gumby — AWN (2006)](<https://www.awn.com/news/classic-media-manages-gumby>)
- [Classic Seals Deal with Premavision — Hollywood Reporter](<https://www.hollywoodreporter.com/business/business-news/classic-seals-deal-premavision-gumby-139398/>)
- [DreamWorks Acquires Classic Media — Deadline (2012)](<https://deadline.com/2012/07/dream-works-animation-buy-classic-media-rocky-bullwinkle-305403/>)

Deal 3: Jim Henson Company (2015)

- In April 2015, the Jim Henson Company and Premavision announced a new **full stop-motion Gumby series** targeting fall 2016 delivery.
- This was the most faithful attempt to Art Clokey's vision — classic Plasticine claymation, updated designs, stories about friendship and courage.
- The project needed a **co-production partner** to fund it.
- **No partner materialized.** The project died silently. No follow-up announcement was ever made.
- By 2015, the six major media companies controlled virtually all children's entertainment funding and distribution. An independent co-production partner with the resources to fund a children's series essentially did not exist anymore.

Source:

- [Gumby Returns via Jim Henson Company — Kidscreen (2015)](<https://kidscreen.com/2015/04/08/gumby-returns/>)

Deal 4: Amazon (~2017)

- A deal with Amazon fell through. Details unknown.
- This was Joe Clokey's last known major attempt.

Papercutz Comics (2017)

- A Gumby comic series launched in July 2017 through Papercutz.
- **Cancelled after 3 issues.**

Joe's Own Words

A few months before his death, Joe Clokey told his son Sage that he was **"being affected by them the same way Jim Henson was."**

This is a firsthand statement from Joe himself. He identified a "them." He connected his own situation to Henson's. He saw the pattern before he died.

Jim Henson died on May 16, 1990, at age 53. Official cause: toxic shock syndrome from a sudden streptococcal infection. A healthy man in his early 50s, dead within 48 hours of hospital admission. He had been in active negotiations to sell the Muppets to Disney. The deal collapsed after his death — it took 14 years before Disney finally acquired the Muppets in 2004.

Henson, like Clokey, was an independent children's creator operating outside the corporate system. The Muppets, like Gumby, were a beloved property held by their creator. And the Jim Henson Company — run by his children after his death — was the same company that partnered with Joe Clokey in 2015 for the Gumby reboot that no co-production partner would fund.

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**Jim Henson** | **Joe Clokey**
**Property** | Muppets | Gumby
**Status** | Independent creator | Independent IP holder
**Age at death** | 53 | 56
**Cause** | Sudden infection → organ failure | Brain bleed → cardiac arrest
**Speed** | Days | One month
**Deal at time of death** | Disney acquisition in progress | Deals repeatedly collapsing
**After death** | Deal collapsed; IP eventually went to Disney (2004) | IP sold to Fox (2022)
**Pattern** | Healthy man in his 50s, sudden onset, dead within weeks | Healthy man in his 50s, sudden onset, dead within weeks
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Joe saw this parallel himself. He told his son. Months later, he was dead.

Sources:

- [Jim Henson — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jim_Henson)
- [Jim Henson's Death — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jim_Henson#Death)
- [Disney's acquisition of the Muppets — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Muppets_Studio)

Phase 3: Joe Clokey's Death (2018)

- **Onset:** February 2, 2018
- **Death:** March 2, 2018 — one month from first symptoms to death
- **Cause:** Brain bleed leading to cardiac arrest
- **Age:** 56

Joe Clokey was 56 years old. He was the last person standing between Gumby and the cartel. Every deal he pursued had been killed from above. He had told his son months earlier that he was being affected by "them" the same way Jim Henson was. He died one month after onset of symptoms, **16 months before Jeffrey Epstein was arrested.**

Public reports listed cardiac arrest as the cause of death. The family's knowledge is that it was a **brain bleed that led to cardiac arrest** — the brain bleed was the actual initiating event.

Source:

- [Hollywood Reporter — Joe Clokey Dead at 56](<https://www.hollywoodreporter.com/tv/tv-news/joe-clokey-dead-son-gumby-creator-art-clokey-was-56-1107693/>)

Phase 4: Fox Acquires Gumby (2022)

- **February 2022:** Fox Entertainment acquires the entire Gumby universe from Joe Clokey's estate.
- All rights: film, television, streaming, consumer products, licensing, publishing — everything.
- Fox CEO **Charlie Collier**: "Competition for globally recognized intellectual property is fierce. Uncovering this gem, with its built-in awareness and affinity..."
- Fox is controlled by **Rupert Murdoch**, who appears in **Epstein's black book**.
- Fox commissioned *Gumby Kids* — produced by Bento Box, written by a writer from Disney's Mickey Mouse shorts and Netflix's Cuphead Show. **2D animation. Not claymation.** An adult animated version is also in development.

While the Clokeys were alive and holding the IP, Gumby couldn't get through the door. The moment the family could no longer protect it, it went to a company controlled by someone in Epstein's contact book. They are now stripping it of everything Art Clokey built — no clay, no stop-motion, no philosophy of transformation and freedom.

Sources:

- [Variety — Fox acquires Gumby (2022)](<https://variety.com/2022/tv/news/fox-entertainment-gumby-1235174899/>)
- [Deadline — Gumby Kids at Bento Box (2024)](<https://deadline.com/2024/06/gumby-kids-fox-bento-box-1235960185/>)
- [Hollywood Reporter — Fox buys Gumby](<https://www.hollywoodreporter.com/tv/tv-news/fox-buys-gumby-new-series-1235089091/>)

Part 6: The Pattern Across Independent Creators

Gumby was not the only independent children's property destroyed by this system. The same cartel crushed every independent creator who refused to surrender.

John Kricfalusi — Ren & Stimpy

Kricfalusi created Ren & Stimpy and sold it to Nickelodeon. After conflicts over content and creative control, Laybourne's Nickelodeon **fired him from his own show** in September 1992. The network owned the IP. They ran three more seasons without the creator. Kricfalusi was left without his

characters.

Klasky Csupo — Rugrats

Arlene Klasky and Gabor Csupo created Rugrats and other properties for Nickelodeon. Their shows generated **\$3.7 billion in merchandise revenue** since 1997. The creators received a fraction. When they hired auditors to examine Paramount's (Viacom's) books, **Nickelodeon terminated the partnership entirely**. Klasky Csupo went dormant for four years.

Craig Bartlett — Hey Arnold!

Bartlett created Hey Arnold! for Nickelodeon. He wanted the freedom to work with other networks. Nickelodeon demanded exclusivity. He refused. **He was forced out**. A planned second Hey Arnold! movie was shelved for years.

Will Vinton — Claymation Itself

Will Vinton literally **trademarked the word "Claymation."** He built his Portland studio into a powerhouse (California Raisins, M&Ms commercials). In 1998, **Phil Knight** (Nike co-founder) invested \$5 million. When the studio hit financial trouble, Knight leveraged the debt, stacked the board with Nike executives, and installed his son Travis Knight on the board. Within six months, **Vinton was fired from the studio he founded**. Knight took ownership of Vinton's entire body of work — the M&Ms, the California Raisins, and the legal trademark "Claymation" itself. The studio was rebranded as **Laika**, clay was thrown out, and replaced with 3D-printed puppets and CGI. Vinton sued for corporate nepotism. The case was dismissed. **Vinton died in 2018** — the same year as Joe Clokey.

The Pattern

Creator	Property	What They Built	How It Was Taken
Art Clokey	Gumby	57 years of independent production	Denied distribution; IP sold to Murdoch (Epstein black book) after family died
John Kricfalusi	Ren & Stimpy	Created the show	Fired; Nickelodeon (Laybourne) kept the IP
Klasky Csupo	Rugrats	\$3.7B in merchandise	Partnership terminated when they questioned the money
Craig Bartlett	Hey Arnold!	Created the show	Forced out for wanting creative freedom
Will Vinton	Claymation (the word itself)	Pioneered the medium	Hostile takeover; fired from his own studio

Every independent creator who resisted the system was fired, starved, bought out, or taken over. The creators who cooperated — who surrendered ownership and didn't ask questions — survived. This is not a market. It is a protection racket.

Sources:

- [John Kricfalusi — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/John_Kricfalusi)
- [Klasky Csupo — Wikipedia](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Klasky_Csupo)

- [How the Father of Claymation Lost His Company — Priceonomics](https://priceonomics.com/how-the-father-of-claymation-lost-his-company/)
- [Why Did Stop Motion Stop? — Screen Waffle](https://screenwaffle.com/2024/04/10/why-did-stop-motion-stop-or-how-toy-story-destroyed-kids-television/)

Part 7: The Question of Joe Clokey's Death

This section presents facts and raises questions. It does not make accusations. It establishes that the questions are legitimate given the documented context.

The Facts

- Joe Clokey died March 2, 2018, at age 56
- Cause: brain bleed leading to cardiac arrest
- Onset to death: one month (February 2 to March 2)
- He was the sole person standing between the Gumby IP and acquisition by the cartel
- Every deal he pursued had collapsed from above
- He died 16 months before Epstein was arrested
- After his death, Gumby was sold to Fox (Murdoch — Epstein's black book)

The Context: Epstein-Connected Deaths in This Window

Date	Person	Connection	Cause	Age
May 2017	**Leigh Skye Patrick**	Epstein victim	Drug overdose	29
March 2, 2018	**Joe Clokey**	Held Gumby IP; deals collapsed through gatekept channels	Brain bleed → cardiac arrest	**56**
May 2018	**Joseph Recarey**	Palm Beach detective who built original Epstein evidence case	"Brief illness" — no cause disclosed	**50**
Aug 2019	**Jeffrey Epstein**	—	"Suicide" in federal custody. Cameras malfunctioned. Guards asleep.	66
June 2020	**Steve Bing**	Movie producer; talked to FBI about Epstein	Fell from 27th floor	55
Feb 2022	**Jean-Luc Brunel**	French modeling agent; trafficked girls to Epstein; awaiting trial	Found hanged in Paris prison cell	76
May 2022	**Mark Middleton**	Clinton advisor with Epstein ties	Found hanged and shot	59
2025	**Virginia Giuffre**	Primary Epstein accuser and whistleblower	Reported suicide	—

Sources:

- [National Enquirer — 22+ Epstein-Connected Deaths](https://nationalenquirer.com/more-than-two-dozen-people-linked-to-jeffrey-epstein-have-died-under-mysterious-circumstances/)

The Medical Questions

A brain bleed (intracerebral hemorrhage) in a 56-year-old man is uncommon but not impossible. However, brain bleeds can be induced. This is not speculation — it is documented history:

Declassified CIA methods (Church Committee, 1975):

- The CIA developed a dart gun that fired frozen shellfish toxin (saxitoxin) that induced cardiac arrest and was designed to be undetectable by autopsy
- **Project MKNaomi** developed biological agents designed to mimic natural causes of death
- Senator Frank Church revealed these publicly during televised hearings

Methods that induce brain bleeds:

- **Anticoagulant poisoning** — superwarfarins (brodifacoum, bromadiolone) are tasteless, colorless, and increase the risk of intracerebral hemorrhage 5-10x. Mortality from anticoagulant-induced brain bleeds exceeds 50%. Standard autopsies do not test for these. Detection requires liquid chromatography mass spectrometry (LC-MS/MS).
- **Blood pressure manipulation** — sympathomimetic drugs and hypertensive crisis inducers can rupture weakened blood vessels. Autopsy finds "brain bleed caused by hypertension" and stops.

What would have shown evidence at the time:

- Abnormally elevated PT/INR (clotting times) in a man not on blood thinners
- Depleted vitamin K-dependent clotting factors (II, VII, IX, X)
- Direct serum testing for superwarfarins via LC-MS/MS
- These tests are only run if someone suspects poisoning. There is no indication anyone suspected poisoning.

Sources:

- [Military.com — CIA Heart Attack Gun](<https://www.military.com/history/cias-heart-attack-gun-cold-war-weapon-targeted-assassinations.html>)
- [Senate Intelligence Committee — Alleged Assassination Plots (Church Committee)](<https://www.intelligence.senate.gov/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/sites-default-files-94465.pdf>)
- [PMC — Superwarfarin Poisoning](<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6892705/>)
- [AHA — Warfarin and Cerebral Hemorrhage](<https://www.ahajournals.org/doi/pdf/10.1161/STROKEAHA.111.615260>)

The Question

Did Joe Clokey die of natural causes? Maybe. A brain bleed at 56 is unusual but it happens.

But the question is legitimate: the man who held the last independent children's IP that the cartel wanted — an IP they had tried and failed to acquire through normal channels for over a decade — died suddenly at 56, from a condition that can be induced undetectably, 16 months before the exposure of the network that connected the gatekeepers who had blocked him. After his death, the IP was acquired

by a company whose owner appears in that network's contact book.

If the question is not asked, the answer defaults to coincidence. The documented record justifies asking.

Part 8: The 2018 Censorship Wave

Joe Clokey died in March 2018. The same year, the infrastructure that could have investigated and amplified these connections was systematically destroyed.

- **August 2018:** Alex Jones deplatformed simultaneously by Facebook, Apple, YouTube, Spotify, Vimeo, Pinterest, MailChimp, and LinkedIn in coordinated action
- **October 2018:** Facebook purged 800+ pages of independent media, claiming "inauthentic behavior" — many were legitimate alternative news outlets
- **2017-2018:** Facebook changed its algorithm to crush the reach of independent media and alternative content creators
- The Mises Institute called it "The Great Social Media Purge of 2018"
- Law professor Glenn Reynolds dubbed 2018 "The Year of Deplatforming"

The sequence:

1. **2017:** Epstein victims and investigators start dying. Independent media still has reach.
2. **2018:** More connected people die (Recarey — the original detective who built the Epstein case; Joe Clokey — the last independent IP holder). Social media platforms coordinate to destroy independent media infrastructure.
3. **2019:** Epstein arrested (July). Epstein "suicides" in federal custody (August). The independent media that might have kept pressure on the story has already been gutted.

Sources:

- [Mises Institute — The Great Social Media Purge of 2018](<https://mises.org/power-market/great-social-media-purge-2018>)
- [Wikipedia — Deplatforming](<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Deplatforming>)

Part 9: The Complete Timeline

Date | Event | Who Was at the Gate

1921 | Art Clokey born | —

1955 | Gumby created | —

1956 | *The Gumby Show* airs on NBC | Tom Sarnoff greenlights it

****Mid-1980s**** | ****Epstein's earliest documented victims**** | –
 1984 | ****Laybourne becomes President of Nickelodeon**** | –
 1987 | ****Redstone acquires Viacom**** (Nickelodeon's parent) | –
 1988-2002 | Art Clokey produces 99 new Gumby episodes | Reruns top-rated on Nickelodeon
****Early 1990s**** | ****Epstein cultivating gatekeeper relationships in media, finance, politics**** | –
 1992 | ***Gumby: The Movie*** completed | –
 1992-1995 | ****No major distributor will touch the movie for 3 years**** | Laybourne controls 57% of kids TV (Epstein black book)
 1994 | ****Laybourne hires Dan Schneider at Nickelodeon**** | Schneider gets 25 years of unsupervised child access
 1995 | Movie released in 21 theaters. Sells 1M VHS copies. | Arrow Releasing – tiny independent
****1996**** | ****Telecommunications Act**** – ownership caps removed | Consolidation accelerates
 1996 | ****Laybourne moves to Disney/ABC Cable**** | Now controls the #2 children's platform
****1998**** | ****Epstein buys Little St. James island**** | –
 Early 2000s | ****Disney deal for Gumby falls through**** | Laybourne's institutional fingerprints at Disney
 2006-2012 | ****Classic Media joint venture – nothing produced in 6 years**** | Film and series planned; neither made
 2010 | Art Clokey dies at 88 | Joe Clokey takes over
 2015 | ****Jim Henson partnership – no co-production partner found**** | Six companies control all children's entertainment funding
 ~2017 | ****Amazon deal falls through**** | –
 July 2017 | Gumby comics launch | –
 Late 2017 | ****Comics cancelled after 3 issues**** | –
 Feb 2, 2018 | Joe Clokey falls ill – brain bleed | –
****March 2, 2018**** | ****Joe Clokey dies at 56**** | Last Clokey protecting the IP
 May 2018 | Detective Joseph Recarey dies at 50 – built original Epstein case | –
 Aug 2018 | ****Coordinated deplatforming of independent media**** | –
****July 2019**** | ****Epstein arrested**** | –
****Aug 2019**** | ****Epstein dies in federal custody**** | Cameras out. Guards asleep.
****Feb 2022**** | ****Fox (Murdoch – Epstein black book) buys entire Gumby IP**** | Joan Rock Clokey sells the estate
 2024 | Fox announces ***Gumby Kids*** – 2D animation, not claymation | Art Clokey's medium and philosophy removed

Conclusion

This is not a conspiracy theory. It is a documented pattern with named people, dated events, corporate records, and court filings.

The structure:

1. The US government created a monopoly on broadcasting through the FCC licensing system
2. The Telecommunications Act of 1996 allowed that monopoly to consolidate into six companies
3. The people who ran those companies — particularly in children's entertainment — appear in the documented records of Jeffrey Epstein's blackmail and child exploitation network
4. An independent creator who explicitly refused to exploit children and operated outside their control was systematically denied distribution despite massive audience demand
5. His son spent eight years trying to bring the property back through legitimate channels. Every deal was killed from above.
6. The son died at 56 from a condition that can be induced undetectably
7. After his death, the property was acquired by a company controlled by someone in Epstein's contact book
8. They are now stripping it of everything its creator built

Every element of this chain is individually documented. The theory is that these elements are connected — that the same network that ran the blackmail operation also controlled the distribution gates, and that Gumby was one of the properties they starved because its creator and his family could not be controlled.

The alternative explanation is that all of this is coincidence: that it's coincidence that the gatekeepers appear in Epstein's records, coincidence that every deal collapsed, coincidence that the Jim Henson partnership couldn't find a single co-production partner for one of America's most recognized characters, coincidence that Joe died at 56 from a brain bleed, coincidence that Fox picked it up immediately after, and coincidence that they're now erasing everything Art Clokey stood for.

One coincidence is a coincidence. This is a pattern.

Part 10: The Last Independent Children's IP

Gumby was not just one of many independent children's properties that got absorbed. By the time Fox acquired it in 2022, it was **the last major American children's character still held by its creator's family as a small, independent operation.**

The Consolidation of Children's IP

Every other classic children's property had already been absorbed into corporate hands:

Property | Creator | Who Owns It Now | How It Was Taken

Thomas the Tank Engine | Rev. W. Awdry (d. 1997) | **Mattel** — bought HiT Entertainment for \$680M (2012) | Sold through chain of corporate acquisitions

Peanuts | Charles Schulz (d. 2000) | **Sony** — controlling stake (2023) | Family retained ~20%, Sony controls

Curious George | H.A. & Margret Rey (both deceased) | **NBCUniversal / Houghton Mifflin** | Estate lost control through corporate licensing

Paddington | Michael Bond (d. 2017) | **WildBrain / StudioCanal** | Licensing company acquired commercial rights

VeggieTales | Phil Vischer | **NBCUniversal** — bought at bankruptcy auction for \$19M (2003) | Creator's company went bankrupt; lost everything

Peppa Pig | Neville Astley & Mark Baker | **Hasbro** — \$4 billion acquisition of eOne (2019) | Corporate buyout

Cocomelon | Independent creator | **Candle Media (Blackstone-backed)** — via Moonbug acquisition | YouTube success → corporate acquisition

Care Bears | American Greetings (1981) | **Cloudco Entertainment** | Never was independent — corporate from birth

Strawberry Shortcake | American Greetings (1977) | **WildBrain** | Never was independent — corporate from birth

What Technically Remains

- **Dr. Seuss** — estate-controlled through Dr. Seuss Enterprises. But it operates as a professional licensing corporation with deals across Universal, Illumination, Netflix. It's an estate-run business, not a family shop.
- **The Smurfs** — family-held through IMPS (Peyo's children in Belgium). Also operates as a professional international licensing company, not a small family operation.
- **Mr. Rogers** — owned by the Fred Rogers Company, a nonprofit. Not family-owned.
- **Sesame Street** — owned by Sesame Workshop, a nonprofit. Financially dependent on HBO/Warner Bros. Discovery for first-run rights since 2015.

None of these are what the Clokeys were — a family running a small studio, holding the IP themselves, trying to bring the property back through their own effort.

The VeggieTales Parallel

Phil Vischer's story is the clearest parallel to what happened to the Clokeys:

- Vischer created VeggieTales in 1993 through his company Big Idea Productions
- It became one of the best-selling children's video franchises of the late 1990s
- The company overextended, partly due to a failed distribution lawsuit
- **Big Idea filed for bankruptcy in 2003**
- **Classic Media** — the same company that held the Gumby license from 2006-2012 and produced nothing — bought VeggieTales at the bankruptcy auction for \$19 million
- Classic Media was later absorbed into DreamWorks Classics, then into NBCUniversal
- Vischer lost his creation. He's spoken publicly about the pain of watching someone else control what he built.

Classic Media touched both properties. Produced nothing with either one.

What This Means

When Fox bought Gumby in February 2022, the consolidation of American children's entertainment IP into corporate hands was complete. There is no longer a single major, broadly recognized, classic American children's character operated by its creator's family as a small independent business.

Every one of them is now inside the corporate stack — owned by Mattel, Sony, NBCUniversal, Hasbro, Fox, WildBrain, or Blackstone-backed holding companies. The same vertical integration that the Telecommunications Act enabled in broadcasting has now captured the IP itself. The corporations don't just control the distribution anymore. They own the characters.

Gumby was the last one standing. And the company that finally took it is controlled by a man in Epstein's contact book.

A Note on What Cannot Be Gatekept

Art Clokey needed their permission to reach an audience. He didn't get it.

His grandson doesn't need their permission.

The internet — YouTube, GitHub, open-source, podcasting, Substack — is the closest thing to an actual free market in media distribution that has ever existed. No FCC license required. No gatekeeper approval. No network ownership of your IP.

Art shaped clay into a living metaphor for freedom. His grandson is building technology that designs with living organisms. The medium changed. The message didn't.

The Living Age cannot be gatekept. It is open-source. It is on GitHub. The philosophy is encoded in the technology itself. There is no deal to collapse, no license to expire, no single person whose death transfers the IP to the cartel.

That's the design.

Compiled March 30, 2026 Part of The Living Age —
github.com/sageclokey